

Textual

Cohesive Devices



In this module, you are learning how to make your written texts cohesive and coherent. To do this well, you will need to use some cohesive devices, words and phrases that help link parts of your writing together. You are not expected to remember the technical language but you are expected to be able to use the devices appropriately.

1. Read the text, which provides you with frequently used cohesive devices and examples of how to use them.
2. Check your understanding of cohesive devices by doing the activity.



Readings



Language awareness: Cohesive devices

In this reading, you will learn ways in which to make your writing cohesive. This is known as cohesion.

There are a number of devices to help make your writing cohesive.

Read the following text. Answer the following question:

Which cohesive device do these words belong to: height, high, higher, highest, highness, highly?

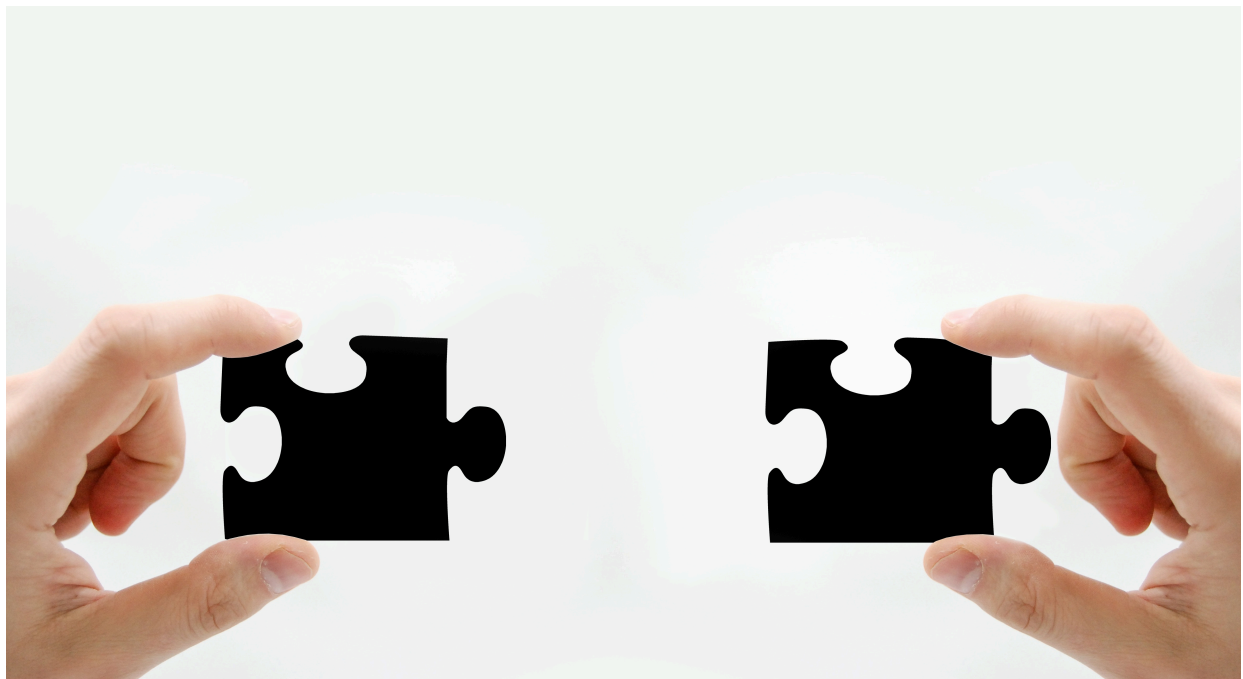
Cohesive devices

There are several ways to make your writing cohesive. You can think of cohesion as the “glue” that holds your text together. Every part of your writing needs to be linked: words should connect to other words, sentences should link to other sentences, and paragraphs should relate to the paragraphs around them.

If parts of your writing do not connect to other parts of the same text, the whole piece will feel disconnected and may “fall apart.” But when clear connections exist throughout the text, your reader can easily “track” how your ideas develop from one point to the next.

Figure 1

[Parts connecting with other parts = cohesion]



Click on each tab to read about each cohesive device.

Referring words



One way of making connections in a text is to use referring words, words which refer back to something that was previously mentioned. The most common referring word is a pronoun *he, she, it, they, him, her, it, them, you, themselves, himself, yourself, yourselves, themselves*, as well as determiners *his, her, my, your, their, its*.

Air pollution is a serious environmental issue. ***It*** is a cause of lung disease.

Substitution



Whereas referring words refer to the same thing, substitution words refer to a different thing.

To compare:

Referring word: *Do you like this research question? I wrote **it** today.*

Research question and **it** are the same thing; that is, the same essay question. There is only one research question being talked about.

Substitution: *Do you like this research question, or do you prefer this **one**?*

The word "**one**" refers to a "research question", but it is a different research question from "**this research question**". There are two research questions being talked about.

Substitution

Repetition



This is a simple kind of cohesion and your reader will be able to follow the text easily. Repetition has its benefits; it can be used for rhetorical purpose to emphasise a point, but, if you use repetition too much, it will not demonstrate a wide range of vocabulary.

Gold, a precious metal, is prized for two important characteristics. First of all, **gold** has a lustrous beauty that is resistant to corrosion. Therefore, it is suitable for jewelry, coins, and ornamental purposes. **Gold** never needs to be polished and will remain beautiful forever.

Oshima, A. & Hogue, A. (1991). *Writing academic English*, Longman.

Deletion



Rather than repeating a word, the word can be deleted if the reader can understand what the omission refers to.

The student read the required reading and wrote an essay.

The student read the required reading and [the student] wrote an essay.

The student said they wrote the essay and they had.

The student said they wrote the essay and they had [written the essay].

Synonyms



Synonyms are words that have a similar meanings.

story and *narrative*; *child* and *kid*.

Antonyms



Antonyms are words that are almost opposite in meaning.

black and *white*; *dull* and *bright*.

Collocation



Collocation refers to words that often appear together. If we are looking for a house to rent, you might read the following in the advertisement:

newly carpeted, freshly painted, not **freshly carpeted, newly painted*".

Others include

Tea and coffee.

Fish and chips.

Word patterns



This refers to groups of words that are related. They could be related because they are the same class of things; or they could be related in terms of whole/part relationship.

Magpies, cockatoos and pigeons are all types of bird.

Our body has a *head, arms, and legs*.

Word chains



The reader can follow your writing by tracking Participants through the text. Word chains are about the different ways you might refer to a particular thing or person. A mother might refer to her child in many different ways.

My daughter, my precious, my little angel, that little brat, my offspring, my pride and joy.

These are not synonyms; rather, they are different words that refer to the one person.

Word forms



Similar to repetition, with word forms, the same base of the word is used throughout the text, but the word form changes, according to the appropriate grammar.

beauty, beautiful, beautify, beautification

(Adapted from Derewianka, 2011)

You were asked a question at the beginning of this reading:

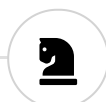
Which one of the devices do these words belong to: *height, high, higher, highest, highness, highly*?

Click on the tab to get the answer.

Answer



word forms



Check your understanding

Cohesive devices

You have been reading about ways in which to make your writing cohesive by using referring words, substitution, repetition, deletion synonym, antonym, collocation, word patterns (umbrella words), and word chains.

To make sure you understand these, do the following activities:

Referring words

Highlight the referring words which refer to crow. Do not mark the full noun "Crow" "Mistress Crow". Only mark pronouns (me, you, we) and determiners (my, his, our).

A Fox once saw a Crow fly off with a piece of cheese in her beak and settle on a branch of a tree.

"That's for me, as I am a Fox," said Master Reynard, and he walked up to the foot of the tree.

"Good day, Mistress Crow," he cried. "How well you are looking today: how glossy your feathers; how bright your eye. I feel sure your voice must surpass that of other birds, just as your figure does; let me hear but one song from you that I may greet you as the Queen of Birds."

The Crow lifted up her head and began to caw her best, but the moment she opened her mouth the piece of cheese fell to the ground, only to be snapped up by Master Fox.

"That will do," said he. "That was all I wanted. In exchange for your cheese I will give you a piece of advice for the future: "Do not trust flatterers."

 Submit

 Reuse

I am confused 

Word patterns.

Highlight all the words that are part of the elephant.

Highlight the words which are parts of the elephant.

Elephants have strong, long trunks that perform multiple tasks, sharp tusks used for carrying heavy objects and for fighting with, large ears which they flap to keep themselves cool as well as having other functions. Elephants also have a tail that with one swish can whisk away flies and other insects making it the perfect fly swatter.

✓ Submit

↻ Reuse

I am confused 🚩

<https://animalcorner.org/elephant-anatomy/>  [\(https://animalcorner.org/elephant-anatomy/\)](https://animalcorner.org/elephant-anatomy/)

Word forms

Highlight all the words that are associate with pollen.

Pollination takes two forms: self-pollination and cross-pollination. Self-pollination occurs when the pollen from the anther is deposited on the stigma of the same flower, or another flower on the same plant. Cross-pollination is the transfer of pollen from the anther of one flower to the stigma of another flower on a different individuals of the same species. Self-pollination occurs in flowers where the stamen and carpel mature at the same time, and are positioned so that the pollen can land on the flower's stigma. This method of pollination does not require an investment from the plant to provide nectar and pollen as food for pollinators.

<https://courses.lumenlearning.com/biology2xmaster/chapter/pollination-and-fertilization/>

✓ Submit

↻ Reuse

I am confused 🚩

Repetition and referring

Highlight all the instances of English and the referring words which refer to English.

Highlight all the instances of English and the words that refer to English.

English has almost become an international language. Except for Chinese, more people speak it than any other language. Spanish is the official language of more countries in the world, but more countries have English as their official or unofficial second language. More than 70 percent of the world's mail is written in English. English is the primary language on the Internet. In international business, it is used more than any other language, and it is the language of airline pilots and air traffic controllers all over the world. Moreover, although French used to be the language of diplomacy, English has displaced it throughout the world. Therefore, unless you plan to spend your life alone on a desert island in the middle of the Pacific Ocean, English is a useful language to know.

(Adapted from Oshima & Hogue, 1991)

 Submit



Questions & Answers

Cohesive devices

If you have any questions, or would like to discuss answers, please post in the

Textual Module: Q&A Discussion Forum

(https://canvas.utscollege.edu.au/courses/7983/discussion_topics/198365)